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EDITORIAL

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Decolonizing fashion [studies] as process

ABSTRACT

In this Special Issue, we explore decolonizing fashion studies not as a destination but as non-linear process, ever revised, re-evaluated, revisited and relived. Situated within a space of self-questioning, the authors in this Special Issue embrace unresolved contradictions and unresolvable paradoxes inherent to the very being of fashion. They are participants, aware that there is no pure pre-colonial space to return to, no 'authentic' pre-colonial dress to resuscitate, accept the multiple means to liberation that emerge through layered/interconnected/tangled histories. In pieces about India, Nigeria, Senegal, Argentina, the United Kingdom and the United States, contributors demonstrate that oftentimes decolonial efforts reinscribe the very power relations they seek to dismantle as a seemingly inescapable condition of capitalist modernity. Yet these conflicted efforts make valuable contributions to social justice. Turning these problems into our theme, we see incompleteness as a path forward rather than an impasse. This introductory essay

KEYWORDS

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examines the unanswerable questions that 'process' or 'being in process' creates. Reflecting critically on the processes of academic publishing as well, we explore giving equal weight to unconventional, open-ended and situated analysis, as well as performative modes of storytelling, illustration and videography, as a strategy toward a future path in fashion studies.

Decoloniality is a process, unachievable in a single bound
(Slade and Jansen 2020: 813)

In *Decoloniality and Fashion* (2020), Slade and Jansen recognize that process is central to decolonial action, and that this process brings instability and challenges to fashion studies. The authors and editors in this Special Issue of *INFS*, which builds on Slade and Jansen's Special Issue of *Fashion Theory*, tease out the ambiguities, contradictions and incompleteness within that process. 'Decolonizing Fashion as Process' is therefore a place of self-questioning rather than certainty. We recognize that unresolved and unresolvable conundrums may be inherent to the very being of fashion. Exploring the necessity and attendant impossibility of conclusively decolonizing fashion studies has implications for knowledge production more widely.

We are writing at a time when decoloniality has gone mainstream in European and North American academia and museums. The concept itself has become an object of enthusiasm, inquiry, doubt and critique. The wide acceptance of this term creates opportunities for increased awareness of decolonial issues, but also dangers in commodifying vital campaigns against racism and inequality, colonial legacies, the structural injustices inherited from the history of slavery, and the ravages of neo-colonialism or internal colonialism (Cusicanqui 2012). Decolonial theories can provide methodological, epistemological and pedagogical tools to challenge colonial structures of power and knowledge. Yet scholars in Europe and the United States can also appropriate Latin American, African and South Asian scholarship to create a new form of colonial domination, excluding without dialogue the very voices whose place they take (Cusicanqui 2012). Here too, ambiguity and uncertainty are irresolvable.

In the field of fashion studies, decoloniality follows on the heels of robust conversations around sustainability, where potential solutions have also proven elusive (Pierson-Smith and Craik 2020). Scholars have welcomed the possibility of a conceptual framework that could eradicate Eurocentrism in the way fashion is categorized, imagined, created, produced, worn, promoted, researched, written about and critiqued (Jansen 2020; Jansen and Craik 2016). Educators even imagined that Eurocentric fashion pedagogies could be decolonized in western institutions (and westernized institutions in the Global South) (Barry 2021). The promise of definite solutions is enticing, but the path towards that promise becomes open-ended. This is in part because there is no pure pre-colonial space, or pre-colonial dress, to return to. In this Special Issue, we therefore explore decolonizing not as a destination but as non-linear process, ever revised, re-evaluated, revisited and relived.

This Special Issue has been crafted to address frustrations with this fugitive destination and to provide intellectual support for scholars who might be experiencing the sense of incompleteness as an impasse. The authors included here embrace that inconclusive sense in order to engage with the decolonial across a range of contexts, geographies, subject positions and topics.

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WORKING WITH DECOLONIALITY

The content of this Special Issue results from two open calls. Initially, Sarah Cheang and Leslie Rabine, acting on behalf of the Research Collective for Decoloniality and Fashion (RCDF), had called for submissions to a double conference session for the *45th Annual Costume Society of America Symposium*, held in Seattle, WA, on 15–20 April 2019. There Arti Sandhu joined the *International Journal of Fashion Studies* guest editorial team. In the common threads that emerged from those conference papers, we saw that once one truly gets into the discourse and methods of decoloniality, they can become problematic and fraught with personal conflict. Turning this problem into our theme, we proposed ‘Decolonizing fashion as process’ for a second, more specific call for research articles and Open Space pieces.

In answering our call, each of the authors here delves into the unanswerable questions that ‘process’ or ‘being in process’ creates when scholars, fashion designers, weavers, dyers, tailors, museum curators, educators, artists or filmmakers set out to decolonize their institutions, subjectivities and practices. Contributors from India, Africa, Latin America, North America and Europe sent us proposals that showed us how this process entails the need to challenge and navigate capitalist enterprises (including universities and museums) that demand the quick resolution of contradictions and the reduction of paradox. Crucially, the authors in this Special Issue do not assume that decoloniality is achievable in full. But they do conceive incompleteness as a way to give value and importance to the ongoing task of decolonizing and its contribution to social justice.

As editors behind the scenes, and as writers ourselves, we could not help but come to reflect on the processes of academic publishing: peer review, vetted methodologies, standardized structures of length, language and tone, as well as the default objective/removed critical stance. In this light, the Open Space section of this journal is a special gift. As editors and contributors, we have made abundant, exuberant, active use of Open Space to experiment with modes of thinking and expression not usually possible in academic double-blind peer-reviewed articles. We have given equal weight to unconventional, open-ended and situated analysis, self-questioning, storytelling, illustration and videography that bubbled up in this project. Most contributors to the Open Space section took the opportunity it offered to publish the kinds of writing and imagery that forego the ‘canon [...] of references and counter references that establish hierarchies’ (Cusicanqui 2012: 8).

On both practical and existential registers, Open Space proved ideal for a Special Issue conceived right before the pandemic, and whose process of writing and editing wended its way in tandem with the up-and-down process of COVID-19. Editors and authors became all too familiar with the uncertainties and incompleteness of ‘process’ on a visceral level. On a mundane level, we editors contended with practical anxieties: Could overwhelmed authors finish articles? Could overwhelmed editors focus on editing? We gradually came to see a connection between the productivity demands of fashion industries (see the pieces by Sandhu, Chauhan and Niessen in this issue) and the productivity demands of academic publishing. Under the stresses of the pandemic, many workers in academic institutions lost publishing productivity. But this enforced loss – along with enforced isolation – brought many people to reflect on how productivity squared with their core values, with what meant the most in their lives. The Open Space section suited the demands of a decolonial

1 This historical and national specificity of decolonality and anti-racism impinges even at the level of tiny detail in our editorial process. Given the differences of ethnic histories in the United Kingdom and North America, we decided to use upper-case 'White' when writing about the United Kingdom (Cheang in this issue) and lower case 'white' when writing about North America (Olowo-Ake in this issue).

thinking that stresses the importance of working 'otherwise' (Cheang et al. 2023: n.pag.). It allowed contributors to publish pieces about what really mattered to them, even though these pieces might not be 'productive' in terms of their careers. Indeed, how can a Special Issue on process and epistemological change avoid questioning process in academic publishing, since authors are addressing the issues at every level (Cheang et al. 2021: 8–10)?

EMBRACING INCOMPLETENESS

Where do we begin?

The authors here do not envision decolonizing fashion as an isolated event, an act that happens and completes itself. This is so whether they are talking about symbols of political independence, artisan/artists resisting economic neo-colonialism, designers resisting cultural imperialism, or efforts to decolonize education, writing, museums and ethnographic research. People in Africa, South Asia and Latin America, as well as immigrants, diasporic communities and Indigenous people in Europe and the United States have been decolonizing fashion for decades, in some cases for centuries. Furthermore, decolonization has no foreseeable ending, no finality or conclusion. Its future iteration remains a question mark.

In William Bamber's historical article on late nineteenth-century Indian fashion, a close exploration of one regional men's style, the Hyderabad *sherwani* and *rumi topi* fashion, reveals the processes through which colonial and decolonial impulses were felt (and recorded) in men's fashion. By recognizing the possibilities of fashionable instability during periods of colonial uncertainty and avoiding any reduction of fashion as either colonial or nationalist, Bamber can write about the contradictions that bedevilled Indian fashion choices during British occupation, and that still bedevil fashion historians when they attempt to read the colonial record without reinscribing its prejudices.

Just as Bamber offers a historic example of regional Indian fashion intersecting with broader colonial frameworks of fashion as a modern body aesthetic, Daniela Lucena explores the avant-garde Genios Pobres movement as it relates to fashion in Argentina during the late 1980s and early 1990s. Lucena argues that their defiant unconventional looks, recycled and frayed, cannot be reduced to the globalization of punk. Nor do they reflect the deconstruction of fashion done by Japanese and Belgian avant-garde designers. Rather, this alternative fashion is rooted in the history, political juncture and cultural spaces of Buenos Aires. From a de-hierarchized and indefinite place, the Genios Pobres fostered a declassified fashion that also expressed social criticism. Their initiatives still influence fashion and textile education in Buenos Aires.

Layered histories, multiple meanings

As the Bamber and Lucena pieces demonstrate, each decolonizing process comes to terms with a specific colonial past and reclaims a specific Indigenous history.¹ Working within the awareness that there is no 'authentic' pre-colonial dress to return to, authors explore alternative paths to accepting the multiple means to liberation that emerge through layered/interconnected/tangled histories. In combination, the pieces about India, Nigeria, Senegal, Argentina, the United Kingdom and the United States show that each effort to decolonize fashion takes place at different moments of history in different locations. Each effort reckons with changing reinterpretations of colonial oppression

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and decolonial liberation. In each national history of decolonizing, one generation takes up a different task from that of the generation before. Members of each new generation reflect upon their life experiences using new words, new awareness, new lenses on the past and the present.

Megha Chauhan, doing field work in craft villages in India, explores the ways that craftspeople incorporate and transpose western individualist models of design education into their own collective ways of thinking, creating and relating. Do these models of western design education harm or enhance local knowledge? Chauhan chooses to remain in the discomfort zone as she finds the answer undecidable. Oluwasola Kehinde Olowo-Ake, working in interdisciplinary design with a collective of African multi-media artists, draws from the forms of Yorubá storytelling she grew up with to free herself and her peers from the racist and neo-colonial frames that try to recapture them. She inserts herself and her colleagues into a process they have inherited, transforming and preserving it. Olowo-Ake and Chauhan, working from within different national and ethnic histories, manifest the historic specificities that bring inconsistencies to decolonizing efforts.

Leslie Rabine reflects upon her own unexamined colonial assumptions while relating the story of a multi-ethnic, multiracial wedding in Dakar, Senegal, where a young groom ambiguously departs from and reaffirms the anti-colonial spirit of his late grandfather. North American curator Amanda Maples describes the processes of collaborating with Senegalese designers to mount a museum exhibition as a decolonial project, even as both curator and designers question the value of the concept and redefine it in their own terms. The Senegalese designers take up the liberating tasks of their own generation. Like Olowo-Ake, they dig into family histories, make new use of old family photographs, and transform the inherited history and myth of the eighteenth-century *signares*.

The myth of true, 'authentic' origins

In Maples's article, the Senegalese designers take their inherited inspiration not from some original pre-colonial model, but from the *signares*, who created their style from a mix of local, European, Indian and Arab cultures. In her article, Chauhan criticizes European craft revivalists who insist that weavers, dyers and block-printers remain faithful to an 'authentic' tradition, thus unwittingly denying to the craftspeople their heritage of continuous creativity. The Indian craftspeople and the Senegalese designers, immersed in the flow of their history, see a continuous process of inter-cultural exchange and creativity, where Eurocentric outsiders might see a stereotyped unified origin.

Similarly, Arti Sandhu analyses the recent trend for minimalist fashion in India and asks if designers' claims of return to a 'purer' past of craftivism and Gandhian principles of handloomed simplicity are marketing strategies. Her analysis circles around to question even the Gandhian principles themselves as having been contrary to popular tastes. Sandhu concludes that it is impossible to identify one definite style or moment of authenticity – past or present – within Indian dress practices.

Irresolvable paradoxes of fashion

The authors here demonstrate – across the Indian fashion industry, in museums, at Lagos Fashion Week, and in higher education – that many decolonial efforts reinscribe the very power relations they seek to dismantle as a

seemingly inescapable condition of capitalist modernity. These re-inscriptions unfold through as yet unresolved contradiction or irresolvable paradox. Chauhan analyses the destructive effects on tradition-based craft communities in rural India when weavers and dyers become subordinate to designers in a capitalist market. Sandhu and Niessen question the very possibility of 'sustainable' fashion when designers and fashion companies must constantly produce new seasonal collections. Chauhan, Sandhu and Hughes analyse the ways that emancipatory decolonial fashion practices are forced to mesh inextricably with neo-colonial exploitative practices. Furthermore, a designer, tailor, weaver, educator or researcher may face conflicting claims, or planes, of existence. For example, a weaver in India or Nigeria may have the responsibility to keep alive and advance ancestral craft values, but at the same time, she must fight for economic survival in the global marketplace. Chauhan studies NGOs involved in navigating this treacherous tightrope. Some try to impose western models of a tradition-to-modernity trajectory, while others seek models of capitalist marketing that, at least in some measure, mesh with ancestral ways of learning and knowing.

Harriet Hughes relates her attendance at Lagos Fashion Week, where organizers and designers build an independent African fashion system and decentre the global fashion map. But to achieve their goals, they must rely on the power structures of Fashion Weeks in London and New York. They must compete for recognition by *Vogue* and other Euro-American media giants. Hughes meets designers who establish made-in-Africa high-end, high-fashion labels by relying on local hand-woven, hand-dyed fabrics, but without giving the skilled weavers and dyers recognition or credit. Sandhu, positioned within the different history and culture of fashion in contemporary India, also finds, in a different form, a series of paradoxes bedevilling the new trend of high-concept, high-end minimalist fashion. These Indian designers, like the Nigerian designers in Hughes's article, rely on highly skilled weavers, dyers and embroiderers in the villages of rural India.

Yet, in an even deeper paradox, Sandhu finds herself captivated by these high-fashion minimalist fashions even as she takes a distanced critical stance. Sandhu remains in aesthetic sympathy with the very trend that she is critiquing. Hughes remains enchanted by the stunning, unique and ultra-showy outfits that the Lagos Fashion Week attendees create with a shoestring budget, a wealth of ingenuity and local knowledge of tailoring and street markets. The authors consciously reframe fashion topics in less Eurocentric ways through a deliberate decolonial effort that then implicates them – and us – as participants in colonial fashion systems.

Refocusing the lens

How then to embrace incompleteness, ambiguity and uncertainty as a path forward rather than an impasse? A scholar who responds to decolonial calls for action may enter an uncomfortable space where they need to change the ways they conceptualize knowledge, identify data and speak about findings. Identity politics can clash with personal emotions or aspirations. Emotions can be especially strong for scholars in fashion studies since fashion epitomizes emotional economies of desire and capitalist economies of financial gain. In common with Maples, Cheang tackles the ways that museums and fashion photography figure within compromised spaces of decolonial reckoning and redress. What drives these narratives are different ways of focusing on

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understanding and coming to terms with positionality as crucial to decolonizing practice and subjectivity, in a continually unfolding process of action and compromise. Where Maples collaborates with Senegalese designers in ways that challenge the ideological limits of a North American museum, Cheang contends with museum space as a hall of mirrors, seductive and horrifying at the same time.

Tanveer Ahmed's article foregrounds her own journey to understanding where decolonial discourse comes from and what it means, but relates this directly to why, how and where fashion education could be decolonized. Ahmed's piece places the emphasis on the processes by which she, when teaching fashion design, came to realize the possibilities available for a decolonial reframing of technique. Her piece therefore focuses on a few foundational tools of fashion design that tend to be taken for granted rather than challenged: the lay pattern and the tape measure.

Performing vs. telling the way forward

In the Open Space section, Olowo-Ake, Ahmed and Sandhu perform ambiguous processes of decolonizing fashion and fashion education. Building on the call for this kind of action (Barry 2021), Ahmed narrates a memoir that leads her to listen to the voices of her Black and Asian diasporic students. Readers follow her life experiences, and come to question, along with her, a pedagogical framework embedded in Eurocentric and capitalist structures. Sandhu performs a visual provocation that reveals the coloniality of another foundational fashion education tool: the illustration. Her own illustrations show viewers new, more decolonial tools. Olowo-Ake deploys storytelling, multimedia collage and video to perform a decolonial challenge to the educational system she endured in the United Kingdom.

In the final piece, Sandra Niessen shares a Defashion manifesto based on the Fashion Act Now activist group, formed from the Extinction Rebellion climate crisis movement. Niessen demonstrates that decolonial principles of equity, justice and redress are indivisible from care for the Earth. The manifesto calls for a paradigm shift in the global fashion system that would not only end the damaging exploitation of resources and people, but also the marketing seductions that hide the grim reality of dire harm to the planet. For Fashion Act Now, there can be no compromise.

INTO THE UNKNOWN FUTURE

Scholars, designers, artisans/artists, educators and curators are continuing to rewrite the histories of fashion in ways that reveal the rich plurality of fashion stories, each with its precious heritage and dignity. Within their multifarious approaches and perspectives, each author in this Special Issue confronts different contradictions because we are collectively, and differently, in process. Each author refuses or criticizes oppressive rules and power relations, and each author ruefully, or rebelliously, examines the need to conform in some way or another to the demands of an academic or capitalist institution. Each seeks to untangle the conflicting threads of a particular historical moment and geo-cultural place of fashion practice.

All five research articles concern West Africa or India, as do three of the seven Open Space pieces. This focus on similar themes in two marginalized regions of the global fashion network hopefully provides a decentring South-to-South comparative framework and dialogue. We hope that this framework

can heighten critical awareness of the mediations that still intrude upon a dialogue held beneath a Euro-American intellectual, ontological umbrella, even as such dialogue contributes to the growing body of work that weakens adherence to the myth of a single universalizing modernity.

Throughout the wealth of ideas/information/paradoxes/proposals/ in this issue, one thing is certain: Our decolonizing efforts will not be pure. They will be mixed and ambivalent. They will struggle, as the authors have struggled, to devise ways of thinking with and through these contradictions. We continue to act, write, teach or produce, without the comfort of finding a perfect solution or the right answer. Avoiding the false façade of a ringing conclusion, we start with an intention to arrive at a given result, knowing that the consequences may stray far from our intention.

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Fashion Now! (with Suzanne Gott, Kristyne Loughran and Betsy Quick, University of Washington Press, 2017). A photographer and graphic designer, Rabine has recently published photos in *Street Art Africa* (Thames & Hudson, 2020).

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